CASE STUDY 06

Creating Reports and Dashboards for Data Visualization in Zoho Creator

Prepared for academic learning and GitHub submission

Abstract

Reports and dashboards turn application records into information that supports operational decisions. This case study uses a service-request tracker to demonstrate report design, chart selection, filtering, key performance indicators, access control, and validation of displayed data.

1. Introduction

Collecting data is only useful when users can retrieve and interpret it. Reports organize individual records, while dashboards combine summaries and visual elements to highlight patterns. In a low-code application, these views can often be configured directly from the underlying form data.

2. Objectives and Scenario

A service team wants to monitor open requests, priority levels, overdue work, technician workload, and average completion time. The dashboard should help supervisors identify bottlenecks without manually combining multiple spreadsheets. The figures must be based on defined and consistently maintained fields.

3. Data Preparation

The underlying request form should contain a request ID, submission date, priority, status, assigned technician, due date, and completion date. Use standard values for status and priority. Define “overdue” clearly, for example as an incomplete request whose due date has passed. Define completion time consistently, such as the difference between submission and completion timestamps.

4. Designing Reports

Create a detailed request report for searching and reviewing individual records. Add filters for date range, status, priority, department, and technician where appropriate. A supervisor may need a team-wide report, while a requester may only need their own records. Sort overdue requests near the top and include the fields needed to take action without cluttering the view.

5. Dashboard Components

A KPI card can show the number of open requests. A bar chart can compare requests by status or technician. A line chart can show incoming requests over time. A priority breakdown can reveal whether urgent work is accumulating. A table of overdue requests can provide direct operational follow-up. Use a chart type that matches the question; avoid too many visualizations or misleading scales.

6. Building and Validating

Use Zoho Creator’s current report and page-building features to configure the required views and add them to a dashboard page. Verify totals against a manually checked sample of records. Test filters and date boundaries, and ensure completed records are excluded from the overdue count if that is the agreed definition. Review the dashboard using different roles to confirm users only see authorized information.

7. Interpretation and Action

A rising open-request count may indicate higher demand or limited capacity. A large overdue share may signal assignment delays, unrealistic due dates, or insufficient resources. Differences between technicians should be interpreted in context, including job complexity and working hours. Dashboards should prompt investigation rather than encourage conclusions from a single metric.

8. Risks and Best Practices

Poor data quality can make charts look precise while being wrong. Missing completion dates distort duration calculations; inconsistent status labels fragment counts. Establish field definitions, monitor incomplete records, and refresh reports at an appropriate frequency. Avoid exposing sensitive customer details in broad dashboards and ensure charts remain understandable on smaller screens.

9. Conclusion

Reports support detailed record review, while dashboards communicate key trends and exceptions. Effective data visualization depends on reliable fields, clear metric definitions, suitable charts, and correct access permissions. Validate calculations against source records before using a dashboard for important business decisions.

References

Official Zoho Creator documentation on reports, charts, pages, dashboards, filters, and permissions.

Note: This document is an educational case study. Verify current platform features, syntax, pricing, and interface details in official documentation.